A GOAN PALACE



08 PALACIO AGUADA, CANDOLIM, GOA

With rates beginning at roughly Rs 21 lakh per night, Palacio Aguada in Candolim, Goa is the benchmark for ultra-luxury. Located on the far end of the Madovi River estuary, this palatial property offers guests a lesson in architectural classifications—from Moroccan courtyards and antique Carrara marble carvings to Gothic archways and neoclassical Greek statues—after greeting them with a two-level entrance crowned by a grand dome. First constructed over 40 years ago by the late Mumbai-based Parsi socialite Jimmy Gazdar, the place was a haven of hedonism in the 1980s and '90s, known especially for NYE parties hosted for the affluent. One such gathering in 2000 introduced Sanjay and Pinky Reddy of the GVK Group to Palacio, prompting them to purchase the property from Gazdar's heirs and transform it into an uber-lavish retreat. One can't book individual rooms at Palacio Aguada. The 10 suites, which can fit up to 20 guests, are available on a full-property buyout basis on invitation only, with a three-night minimum stay requirement.



BEYOND BALI

09 SUMBA, INDONESIA

Sumba, in eastern Indonesia, boasts one of Southeast Asia's last truly untamed coastlines. Here, the rhythms of daily life remain beautifully slow, defined by traditional thatched settlements, heritage ikat weaving studios, and grazing sandalwood ponies. While global surf travellers revere the island for its legendary left-hand wave break, luxury-seekers find solace at the ultra-exclusive Nihi Sumba, which commands miles of untouched private shoreline. Sumba's rising popularity is balanced perfectly by its challenging accessibility, a geographical hurdle that keeps the crowds at bay and preserves a raw, wild spirit distinct from neighbouring Bali.

AFRICAN OPULENCE

10 ZARAFA CAMP, SELINDA RESERVE

Tucked deep within Botswana's pristine Selinda Reserve, Zarafa Camp delivers an ultra-exclusive retreat managed by Great Plains Conservation, the eco-tourism venture co-founded by wildlife filmmakers Dereck and Beverly Joubert. Operating entirely on solar energy, this ultra-intimate sanctuary features only four guest suites. Given its founders' cinematic roots, the camp uniquely designs its daily itineraries around an immersive wildlife photography programme. For veteran explorers who have already traversed the crowded plains of the Serengeti or the Maasai Mara, Zarafa offers a remarkably peaceful, highly private alternative that showcases low-impact African luxury. ■

